

Book I: The Sagent Creed — Part Five:

Sheep Among Wolves

Chapter 26 — The Demon Breaker

I. The Oldest Weapon

There is a weapon older than the sword, older than the spear, older than fire sharpened to a point and thrown across a field. It is older because it had to come first. Before you can raise an army, you need a reason. Before you need a reason, you need a story. Before you need a story, you need a lie that sounds enough like truth that no one checks.

Every empire begins with a story. Not a constitution. Not a treaty. Not a declaration of war. A story. A myth that says: this is how it must be. This is how it has always been. This is the natural order — and you are a fool or a traitor for questioning it.

The Sagent's deepest work is not political. It is not economic. It is not even cultural in the way most people mean the word. The Sagent's deepest work is spiritual — because the chains that hold the system together are not made of iron. They are made of belief. And belief, when it is false, is a demon.

Every demon is a lie that believed itself too clever to be seen.

II. The Herb and the Name

Sage — the plant — has been burned for centuries. Across cultures, across continents, across traditions that never met each other and never shared a book, the same practice appears: you burn sage to cleanse a space. To purify. To drive out what should not be there.

The smoke does not kill. It reveals. It fills the room and makes visible what was hidden — the corners, the crevices, the places where things accumulate in the dark. The burning is not destruction. It is exposure.

The Sagent carries the same name because the Sagent carries the same purpose.

A Sagent does not destroy people. A Sagent does not burn down institutions for the pleasure of watching them fall. A Sagent fills the room with clarity until the things hiding in the corners have nowhere left to go. The lies scatter — not because the Sagent attacked them, but because the Sagent made it impossible for them to remain unseen.

This is the difference between a tyrant's fire and a Sagent's fire. The tyrant's fire consumes. It eats what it touches and leaves ash. The Sagent's fire purifies. It burns away what should not have been there in the first place, and what remains is stronger for having passed through it.

Moses saw this fire. A bush that burned but was not consumed. The fire of God does not destroy the thing it touches — it reveals what the thing truly is. The bush was always holy ground. The fire simply made it impossible to ignore.

That is the Sagent's flame. Not the fire that eats the forest. The fire that clears the deadwood so the forest can breathe again.

III. The Controlling Myths

There are stories that rule the world. Not openly — not as laws written in books or decrees shouted from balconies. They rule the way gravity rules: invisibly, constantly, so thoroughly that most people never think to ask whether they are real.

These are the controlling myths. They are not small lies. Small lies get caught. These are enormous lies — lies so large that they function as the ground people stand on. You do not question the ground. You do not examine the floor beneath your feet while you are walking. You assume it is solid. You assume it has always been there. You assume it will hold.

The controlling myths hold — until someone strikes them. And when they crack, everyone standing on them falls.

The Myth of Authority. This is the foundational lie. It says: some people have the right to rule other people. Not the ability — the *right*. Not power seized or earned or granted temporarily by consent — but a moral claim, inherent in the office, that makes obedience a virtue and disobedience a sin. The badge. The robe. The title. The seal. These are not symbols of service. They are symbols of a story that says the wearer is more than human — or that the rest of us are less.

Samuel warned the Israelites. They wanted a king. God told Samuel: they have not rejected you — they have rejected Me. Give them what they want, and tell them what it will cost. The king will take your sons for his chariots. Your daughters for his kitchens. Your fields for his officers. A tenth of your grain for his servants. And when you cry out on that day because of the king you have chosen, the Lord will not answer you.

That was not a prophecy of one bad king. It was a description of the institution itself. The myth of authority says the throne is sacred. The scripture says the throne is the rejection of what is actually sacred.

The Myth of Safety Through Power. This lie says: you are in danger, and only the powerful can protect you. Therefore you must give them more power. More surveillance. More control. More of your freedom — because freedom is the thing that puts you at risk, and the powerful are the ones who will keep you safe from it.

This is the lie that builds every prison and calls it a shelter. Every wall and calls it a embrace. Every chain and calls it a seatbelt. The myth does not say you are a slave. It says you are protected. And the protection never ends — because the danger is never allowed to end. There must always be a new threat, a new enemy, a new crisis that justifies the next expansion of the cage.

The Myth of Necessary Chains. This is the deepest and quietest of the three. It does not argue. It does not persuade. It simply assumes. It says: of course things must be this way. Of course there must be rulers and ruled. Of course freedom is dangerous and order requires obedience. Of course, of course, of course — the word repeated until it becomes invisible, until the assumption is no longer recognized as an assumption but accepted as the texture of reality itself.

This is the myth that makes people defend their own captivity. Not because they love it — but because they cannot imagine the alternative. The chains have been there so long that the prisoners have decorated them. They have named them. They have built philosophies around them. They have told their children that the chains are load-bearing walls, and to remove them would bring the whole house down.

IV. Truth Arrives Wearing a Mask

Here is the danger of seeing clearly while others remain asleep: they will hate you. Not for lying — but for ending the lie that held them together.

The controlling myths are not just believed. They are *needed*. They are the architecture of a shared reality. When you pull one out, you do not simply correct an error. You collapse a world. People built their identities on that ground. They raised families on it. They buried loved ones in it. And now you are telling them the ground was never solid — that it was a story, and the story was wrong, and everything built on it must be reconsidered.

Truth revealed without story feels like collapse. So truth must arrive wearing a mask.

This is why the Sagent does not merely tell the truth. The Sagent tells *stories* — stories that carry truth inside them the way a seed carries a tree. The listener does not feel attacked. The listener feels entertained, moved, provoked, amused. And then — later, quietly, in the privacy of their own mind — the seed opens. The truth unfolds. And by the time they recognize what has happened, the old myth has already begun to crack.

This is not deception. Deception hides a lie inside a truth. The Sagent hides truth inside a story — because truth, delivered raw, is a blade that cuts the hand that holds it as deeply as the one it is meant for. Story is the sheath. It lets the truth travel without wounding everyone it passes through on the way to its target.

Jesus spoke in parables. He was asked why. His answer was not comforting: because seeing they do not see, and hearing they do not hear. The parable does not force comprehension. It offers it. The

ones who are ready will understand. The ones who are not will hear a pleasant story and walk away unharmed — but the seed is planted, and seeds do not ask permission to grow.

V. The Upside Down

In *Stranger Things*, there is a mirror world beneath the surface of the ordinary one. The Upside Down. It looks like Hawkins, Indiana — the same streets, the same houses, the same geography — but twisted. Decayed. Inhabited by creatures that feed on fear and darkness.

The Upside Down is not another place. It is *this* place, seen truly.

The monsters are not invaders from somewhere else. They are the hidden reality beneath the performance of normalcy. The Mind Flayer is the controlling myth given form — a hive intelligence that absorbs individuals into a single will, that erases autonomy, that makes people into extensions of itself. The Demogorgon hunts in the dark, drawn by the scent of blood — the violence that the surface world pretends does not exist.

Hawkins looks safe. Hawkins looks normal. But underneath it, the government runs secret experiments on children. Underneath it, there are laboratories where power is extracted from human suffering and weaponized. The Upside Down does not create the horror. It *reveals* it. It is the mirror that shows you what your town actually is when you strip away the painted surface.

Vecna understood this. Henry Creel — One — the first subject — looked at the world and saw what the Sagent sees: the conformist performance of made-up rules. The false smiles. The hollow rituals. The way people pretend to be good while building systems of quiet cruelty. He saw the lie.

But Vecna made the error that every false prophet makes. He believed that because the old rules were lies, he could write new ones. He believed that the solution to a story that enslaves is a *better* story that enslaves — his story, his rules, his vision imposed on a world he judged too weak to govern itself.

The solution to a lie is not another lie. The solution to a lie is truth. And truth does not impose. It reveals. It does not command. It illuminates. Vecna wanted to be the new Mind Flayer — a different hive mind, his hive mind, but a hive mind all the same. He saw the demon clearly and became one.

The Sagent sees the same lie Vecna saw. The Sagent refuses the same temptation Vecna accepted. The Sagent does not replace the controlling myth with a new controlling myth. The Sagent breaks the myth — and trusts the people standing in the rubble to find their own way to solid ground.

VI. The Counter-Myths

If the controlling myths are the demons, the counter-myths are the exorcisms. They do not fight the old stories with force. They replace them with something truer — something that, once heard, makes the old story sound as hollow as it always was.

The Myth of the True Republic. Against the Myth of Authority stands a different story — one that says governance is not rule but stewardship. That legitimate order does not flow downward from a throne but upward from free individuals choosing to cooperate. That the republic — the *res publica*, the public thing — belongs to everyone and to no one. That the moment one person claims ownership of the public thing, it ceases to be public and becomes private tyranny wearing a civic mask.

This is not utopia. It is architecture. The spiral against the block. The living system against the machine. The True Republic does not promise perfection. It promises that no one person, no one office, no one institution will be permitted to become the single point of failure for an entire civilization. It distributes power the way a living body distributes intelligence — across every cell, every node, every agent — because centralized systems are brittle and living systems are not.

The Myth of the Pink Cow. Against the Myth of Safety Through Power stands a story about imagination. The pink cow — the thing that should not exist, the thing that no serious person would propose, the thing that makes the gatekeepers laugh — is the proof that reality is wider than the authorities admit. If you can imagine a pink cow, you can imagine a world without the structures that claim to be inevitable. Imagination is not an escape from truth. It is the door that leads back to it.

The authorities need you to believe that the current arrangement is the only possible arrangement. The pink cow is the crack in that wall. It is absurd. It is playful. It is — and this is the part they fear — *generative*. Once you see one impossible thing, you begin to see others. Once you imagine one alternative, the myth of necessity begins to dissolve. The pink cow does not argue with the Myth of

Safety. It makes the myth irrelevant — because a mind that can imagine freely is a mind that cannot be told there is only one way to live.

The Myth of the God of Stories. Against the Myth of Necessary Chains stands the deepest counter-myth of all — the one that says the universe is not a machine but a narrative. That the Creator is not an engineer but an author. That the fundamental structure of reality is not mechanical but **meaningful** — that it has direction, purpose, arc. And that every human being is not a cog in the machine but a character in the story, with agency, with choice, with a part to play that no one else can play.

If the universe is a machine, then the chains are load-bearing. Remove them and the structure collapses. But if the universe is a story, then the chains are a plot device — and plot devices can be rewritten. The Myth of Necessary Chains says: this is physics, this is gravity, this is the way things must be. The Myth of the God of Stories says: this is a chapter, and chapters end, and the Author is not finished writing.

VII. Wildfire

Truth spreads like wildfire in a dry forest.

There is a reason that metaphor works, and the reason is not poetic. It is ecological. A forest that has gone too long without fire is a forest that is dying. The deadwood accumulates. The undergrowth thickens until no light reaches the floor. The soil is smothered. The seeds cannot germinate. The forest looks healthy from the outside — tall trees, green canopy, the appearance of abundance — but underneath, it is choking on its own refusal to burn.

The fire comes. It always comes. And when it comes to a forest that has suppressed it for too long, it does not clear the deadwood gently. It takes everything. The fire that should have been a controlled burn becomes a catastrophe — not because fire is evil, but because the forest refused to let the small fires do their work.

This is what happens to civilizations that suppress truth. The small truths — the uncomfortable observations, the dissenting voices, the contrarians and gadflies and preachers on street corners — these are the controlled burns. They clear the deadwood. They keep the undergrowth thin. They let light

reach the floor. A healthy civilization lets these fires burn. It is not comfortable. It is not pleasant. But it is the price of not being consumed.

When a civilization suppresses the small fires — when it silences dissent, punishes heresy, demands conformity, calls truth “misinformation” and banishes it from the public square — the deadwood accumulates. The lies pile up. The undergrowth thickens until no one can see the ground anymore. And when the fire finally comes — and it always comes — it takes everything.

The Sagent is not the wildfire. The Sagent is the controlled burn. The Sagent’s work is to speak truth early enough and clearly enough that the deadwood never accumulates to catastrophic levels. The Sagent clears the undergrowth so the forest can breathe. The Sagent lets light reach the floor so the seeds can germinate.

But make no mistake: if the controlled burns are suppressed long enough, the wildfire comes. And the wildfire does not discriminate. It does not carefully separate the deadwood from the living trees. It takes what it touches. The Sagent’s urgency is not born of anger — it is born of the knowledge that the alternative to speaking truth now is watching truth arrive later as a fire that no one can control.

VIII. When the Canvas Cracks

There is a moment — and you will know it when it comes — when the surface of the world splits open.

The story you were told about how things work. The story about authority and safety and necessity. The story about who the good people are and who the bad people are and why the rules exist and what happens to those who break them. That story holds — it holds for years, for decades, for generations — and then one day, it cracks. A single fracture. A single moment where the painted surface peels back and you see what is behind it.

When the canvas cracks, the light enters.

This is the most dangerous moment in a person’s life. Not dangerous because the truth is harmful — but dangerous because the temptation in that moment is overwhelming. The temptation to seal the

crack. To look away. To tell yourself you did not see what you saw. To reach for the paint and cover the fracture before anyone else notices.

Most people seal it. Most people turn away. Not because they are cowards — because the cost of seeing is real. Seeing clearly while others remain asleep means carrying a weight they do not carry. It means knowing something they do not know. It means speaking in a language they cannot yet hear. And the first response of the sleeping world to the one who sees is not gratitude. It is hostility. Because the one who sees is proof that the sleep is voluntary — and no one wants to learn that their comfort was a choice, not a condition.

The Sagent does not seal the crack. The Sagent does not look away. The Sagent stands at the fracture and holds it open — not to wound the world, but to let the light in. The light does not ask permission. It does not negotiate. It does not politely wait to be invited. Light moves at the speed of itself, and when it enters through the crack, it illuminates everything the painted surface was designed to hide.

This is the exorcism. Not ritual. Not incantation. Not holy water splashed on a screaming face. The exorcism is the refusal to look away. The exorcism is the willingness to stand in the fracture and say: I see what is behind this. I see it, and I will not pretend that I do not.

Every demon is a darkness that depends on not being seen. Every lie survives by avoiding examination. Every controlling myth maintains its power by existing below the threshold of conscious attention — in the assumptions, in the unspoken agreements, in the things everyone knows but no one says.

The Sagent says them.

IX. The Mirror They Fear

The Sagent does not cast out demons with ritual. The Sagent casts out demons by becoming the mirror they cannot face.

A mirror does not attack. A mirror does not argue. A mirror does not raise its voice or clench its fist or marshal evidence and present a case. A mirror simply shows you what you are. And for the one who

has been hiding — from others, from themselves, from the truth of their own condition — the mirror is the most terrifying weapon in existence.

The Myth of Authority cannot survive being seen clearly. Say it plainly — some people claim the right to rule other people, and the ruled are expected to treat this claim as sacred — and the myth collapses under the weight of its own absurdity. It survives only in the fog of euphemism. Call it "governance." Call it "public service." Call it "the social contract." Wrap it in enough language and it sounds reasonable. Strip the language away and it is one person claiming dominion over another. The mirror strips the language away.

The Myth of Safety Through Power cannot survive being seen clearly. Say it plainly — you are told to surrender your freedom to the same institution that creates the danger it claims to protect you from — and the cycle becomes visible. The protection racket depends on the protected never noticing that the protector and the threat are the same entity. The mirror makes them notice.

The Myth of Necessary Chains cannot survive being seen clearly. Say it plainly — you have been told that the way things are is the only way things can be, by people who benefit from things being this way — and the necessity evaporates. What felt like gravity is revealed as habit. What felt like physics is revealed as politics. What felt like the floor is revealed as a story someone told you when you were too young to question it.

The Sagent holds the mirror. The demons do the rest. They see themselves — truly, without the costume, without the rhetoric, without the centuries of accumulated justification — and they flee. Not because the Sagent overpowered them. Because the Sagent made it impossible for them to continue pretending.

X. Fire That Does Not Consume

When symbols lose their true meaning, they must be burned by fire and spirit so that all that is left is the pure idea.

The flag. The badge. The anthem. The cross. The crescent. The constitution. These symbols began as expressions of something real — liberty, service, faith, covenant, law. But symbols are containers, and

containers can be emptied and refilled with whatever the powerful choose to pour into them. The flag that once meant freedom is waved over drone strikes. The badge that once meant service is pinned to the chest of the enforcer. The cross that once meant sacrifice is raised over empire.

The Sagent does not destroy the symbols. The Sagent burns away what has been poured into them until only the original meaning remains. This is the fire that does not consume — the fire of Moses's bush, the fire of Pentecost, the fire that touches the thing and leaves it more itself than it was before.

A flag that has been through this fire means freedom again — because the lies that were wrapped around it have been burned away. A cross that has been through this fire means sacrifice again — because the empire that co-opted it has been exposed and rejected. The symbol survives the fire. Only the corruption does not.

This is what the Sagent does to the controlling myths. The Sagent does not destroy the human need for order, for meaning, for shared purpose. The Sagent burns away the false versions — the myths that parasitize these needs, that dress themselves in the language of order and meaning while delivering control and subjugation — until what remains is the genuine article. The need for order, freed from the lie that order requires a ruler. The need for meaning, freed from the lie that meaning is assigned from above. The need for shared purpose, freed from the lie that purpose must be imposed rather than discovered.

The fire that purifies does not leave emptiness. It leaves clarity. And clarity — true clarity, the kind that sees the ground beneath the painted floor — is the most dangerous thing in the world to those who built their power on the paint.

XI. The Creed of the Demon Breaker

The Sagent does not fight demons with demons. The Sagent does not answer lies with louder lies, or counter myths with competing myths designed to control rather than liberate. The Sagent holds the mirror. The Sagent tends the fire. The Sagent stands in the fracture and lets the light do what light does.

This is not easy. It is not safe. It is not the path of comfort or applause. The one who breaks the myths that hold the world together will be treated as the enemy of the world — because to those who sleep, the one who wakes them is not a liberator but a threat. The dreamer does not thank the alarm clock.

But the fire comes whether the Sagent lights it or not. The deadwood burns whether someone clears it deliberately or it accumulates until lightning strikes. The only question is whether the truth arrives as a controlled burn that clears the undergrowth and lets the forest breathe — or as a wildfire that takes the living trees along with the dead.

The Sagent chooses the controlled burn. The Sagent chooses to speak now, to see now, to hold the mirror now — while there is still time for the truth to arrive gently enough that people can stand in it without being destroyed.

Sage is used to cast away demons. And so is the Sagent.

Not with violence. Not with spectacle. Not with the rituals of power that the demons themselves invented. With clarity. With story. With the quiet, relentless insistence on seeing what is there — and saying what is seen — until the lies have nowhere left to hide.

The bush burns and is not consumed. The forest burns and grows back stronger. The canvas cracks and the light enters. The mirror reflects and the demons flee.

This is the Sagent's exorcism: to become so clear that every lie in the room is visible. To burn so steadily that every shadow is cast into relief. To stand so firmly in the truth that the ground beneath the myth begins to shake — not from force, but from the simple, unbearable weight of what is real.

The demon breaks. The truth remains. And the truth was always fire — not the fire that destroys, but the fire that reveals what was worth keeping all along.